Who Do We Ask About What?

Questions to bring to each professional as you plan ahead for Mom's care, with room to write what they say.

Planning ahead doesn't mean answering every question yourself. It means knowing which questions exist and whose desk each one belongs on. Bring them written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on Mom's situation and on where she lives, and the people below are the ones who can speak to it. Nothing here has to be asked this month. The questions keep.

Mom, and the family

The questions only your family can answer. Start with Mom.

1. Mom, if you needed more help one day, where would you want to be, and who would you want helping?

2. If you couldn't manage your money or make healthcare decisions for a while, who would you want handling each?

3. Which of us should take part in planning, and who would be the first to notice a change?

Mom's doctor

With Mom in the room, or with her say-so.

1. Given Mom's health today, what kinds of help might she need in the coming years, and which changes would you want to hear about?

Your Medicaid planner

The person who brings Mom's care needs, her preferences, her finances, what you've learned about Medicaid and her existing legal documents into one picture.

1. Looking at what we've pulled together, what should we do first?

2. Which parts can we handle ourselves, and where do we need professional help?

3. If Mom ever needed to apply for Medicaid, what in our situation would you want to look at before then?

4. Which of the things on our list can be addressed now, and which should we simply keep an eye on?

5. Which changes in Mom's situation should make us pick this up again?

An elder law attorney

For questions about legal documents, and about who may act for Mom.

1. Here are the legal documents Mom has, and the date on each. Which would you want to review?

2. What would need to be in place for someone to handle Mom's financial matters, or her healthcare decisions, if she couldn't?

3. Our family has talked about changing how some of Mom's money or property is held. What should we understand before anyone does anything?

A licensed financial professional or a licensed insurance professional

For questions about insurance, and about ways of paying for long-term care.

1. Here is the insurance Mom has now. What does each policy cover, and what doesn't it cover?

2. Which ways of paying for long-term care would you want us to understand, given Mom's situation?

A tax professional

1. Could any of the things our family is thinking about affect Mom's taxes, and what would you need from us to say?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, put them in order of importance, or say what any answer means for Mom. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Questions about Medicaid, the law, money or taxes go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and you know whose desk each one belongs on. The planning interview gives the answers somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

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